Examining the Dynamics of Changing Tastes*

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Abstract

Does cultural taste primarily flow from shifting social networks, or do durable cultural tastes help stabilize personal communities over time? Network transmission models posit that tastes are volatile and decay when social ties are disrupted, whereas cultural capital models posit that tastes are enduring dispositions that facilitate tie maintenance. Using longitudinal panel data from the Project Canada Survey (1985–1995), I adjudicate between these frameworks via discrete-time pooled logistic and Mundlak Poisson models. I find that cultural tastes exhibit remarkably high levels of over-time stability (roughly 98% retention over five years), countering standard network volatility assumptions. However, when taste loss does occur, it is significantly driven by network turnover, such as disrupted friendships or organizational memberships. Furthermore, holding durable cultural breadth (omnivore tastes) longitudinally predicts higher rates of maintained social connectivity. These findings suggest a theoretical synthesis: while stable cultural capital acts as a selective filter to maintain social ties, severe structural network shocks can subsequently erode cultural practices.

Introduction

Prevailing models of taste formation, transmission, and decay in the sociology of culture posit that current tastes are largely a product of the individual's current

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network configuration. The standard assumption is that tastes are transmitted through existing network ties, in particular those social connections characterized by sociodemographic similarity (Lazarsfeld and Merton 1954; McPherson, Smith-Lovin, and Cook 2001). From this perspective, tastes are not enduring aspects of the person but malleable, "thin" contents liable to change when network ties change (Mark 1998b, 2003). Given that personal networks are highly volatile (Burt 2000; Suitor, Wellman, and Morgan 1997), this network perspective implies that cultural tastes should also exhibit significant instability over time.

In contrast, the cultural capital model (Bourdieu 1984; Holt 1998) conceives of cultural tastes as highly durable dispositions. Formed early in life, these embodied cultural practices are resistant to change and serve as stable resources to maintain and forge network connections (Lizardo 2006). Rather than being at the mercy of shifting networks, stable cultural tastes may act as a reciprocal driver of network maintenance, enabling individuals to sustain interaction across constantly shifting personal communities.

This research note empirically adjudicates between these divergent expectations using longitudinal panel data. Specifically, I address the following research questions: (1) Do cultural tastes exhibit the high volatility implied by network transmission models, or the high stability expected by cultural capital models? (2) When cultural taste loss does occur, is it primarily driven by life-course events associated with network turnover? (3) Does a broad, stable repertoire of cultural tastes (cultural capital) longitudinally predict the maintenance of social connectivity, independent of reciprocal effects?

By leveraging the Project Canada Survey (1985-1995) and employing modern panel data estimators (discrete-time pooled logits and Mundlak within-between Poisson models), this note provides a direct test of the cultural capital versus network transmission frameworks.

Data and variables

The data for this study come from the *Project Canada Survey* (PCS). The PCS is a longitudinal study of the social attitudes and cultural practices of a representative sample of Canadian citizens extending from 1975-1995, conducted out of the University of Lethbridge. The project began data collection in 1975 with a total 1,917 respondents. Every five years since representative samples of similar size have been collected, with a "core" set of respondents that have participated in previous surveys. Because it collected data on cultural practices and patterns of social interaction and membership in important foci of social interaction (i.e. voluntary association memberships) over time for the same individuals, the PCS data provide an excellent opportunity to deal with issues of casual order in the relationship between cultural taste loss and life-course events associated with network turnover.

In the following study, I use the longitudinal panel covering the core years of 1985, 1990, and 1995, focusing on the core set of respondents who participated across these waves. While previous analyses restricted themselves to the 1985–1990 window to avoid coding inconsistencies in 1995 and age-related taste declines, the use of modern longitudinal estimators (such as Mundlak within-between models with wave fixed-effects) allows us to gracefully handle both age-related secular trends and programmatic harmonization of the taste indicators across the entire panel timeframe.

Data limitations. While this data provide one of the few existing quantitative sources of information of cultural taste over-time for a large sample of respondents, there are some limitations that deserve mention: there are no direct measures of network connectivity (i.e., size of the personal network). The two measures available, frequency of interaction with friends and number of associational memberships, are important components of sociability but do not capture network properties entirely. To address the slight changes in the coding of cultural activities across waves (such as the shift to a 7-point frequency scale in 1995), all indicators have been programmatically harmonized back to the original 4-point scale (Very often, Sometimes, Seldom, Never) prior to estimation.

Variables

Cultural Taste indicators

Cultural taste loss indicators. The PCS collected information across the 1985, 1990, and 1995 waves related to the frequency of consumption of a variety of leisure culture activities and mass media outlets. Because of wording and coding changes across survey waves for several activities, I examine four specific at-home activities that were coded consistently over time: (1) listening to music, (2) following a sports team, (3) reading the newspaper, and (4) reading books of fiction. This selection captures a wide array of potential taste changes over time. Respondents were asked to report the frequency with which they engaged in each of these activities using the following prompt:[1]

Thinking now of your life outside of formal work, how often would you estimate that you: [i.e. listen to music]?

Four categories of responses were allowed: (1) very often, (2) sometimes, (3) Seldom and (4) Never.[2] Thus for each respondent (i), for a given cultural activity (k) at time (t) is defined as their score in the respective ordered categorical variable $y_{ikt.}$

Cultural taste breadth indicators. To assess the hypotheses connected to the effects of cultural taste on indicators of sociability and social connectivity, I created a cultural taste breadth variable for the 1980, 1985, 1990, and 1995

[1]The various codebooks for all waves of the PCS survey (1975, 1980, 1985, 1990 and 1995) are available online at: http://www.thearda.com/Archive/IntSurveys.asp.

[2]As noted above, the 1990 coded the same variables using a slightly more elaborate categorization. I recoded those variables to match the 1985 scheme.

waves. This is a simple additive index indicating participation in a wide range of cultural activities. Using the same set of items, the respondent receives one point in the cultural taste breadth scale if he or she reports engaging in the following cultural practices either "very often" or "sometimes": (1) listening to music, (2) going to the movies, (3) going to a theatric performance, (4) going to a sports event outside the home, (5) watching videos at home, (6) engaging in a hobby, (7) reading magazines, (8) following a sports team, (9) reading a novel or book, and (10) reading the newspaper.

Network turnover indicators

As noted above, network theory and research provide several guidelines as to what life-course events are associated with radical changes in the personal network. The PCS contains two measures that tap more or less direct transformations of the personal network: (1) longitudinal changes in frequency of interaction with friends and (2) over-time changes in memberships across a variety of voluntary associations (McPherson 1983; McPherson and Smith-Lovin 1987). I also use five other indicators of personal network turnover based on positional shifts: (3) changes in educational status (Suitor and Keeton 1997) (4) changes in work status (Fischer and Oliker 1983), (5) changes in geographical location (Degenne and Lebeaux 2005), (6) changes in marital status (Fischer and Oliker 1983) and (7) changes in child rearing status (Munch, McPherson, and Smith-Lovin 1997). Since a non-negligible part of the individual's personal network comes from contacts that are often seen at work (Brass 1985; Ibarra 1992; Straits 1996), we should expect that either entrance into or exit from the labor force, or shifts from part-time to full-time work, should have a clear impact on the size and composition of the personal network over time (Bidart and Lavenu 2005). The same can be said of geographical mobility (Relish 1997), with geographically mobile respondents more likely to be subject to radical transformation of their personal networks from those who are not mobile.[3] Finally, a large body of research shows that family status transitions, such as getting married or getting divorced (Gerstel 1988; Leslie and Grady 1985; Milardo 1987; Pahl and Pevalin 2005) and experiencing widowhood (Anderson 1984; Morgan, Carder, and Neal 1997; Morgan, Neal, and Carde 1997), have significant effects on the social networks of men and women. We should thus expect that transformations in family life, such as getting divorced, getting married or having children (Belsky and Rovine 1984; Bott 1971; Munch, McPherson, and Smith-Lovin 1997), should result in direct effects on the size and composition of the personal network.

[3]The nominal employment status from which the binary indicator for changes in work status is constructed from has six categories (1) full time, (2) part time, (3) unemployed, (4) retired, (5) keeping house, and (6) other. The geographical mobility item is based on the region in which respondent reported residing in each wave. The marital status variable has five categories: (1) married, (2) cohabiting, (3) divorced, (4) widowed and (5) never married.

Social connectedness indicators

In order to test the cultural capital hypotheses (3 and 4), I use two indicators of social connectivity: (a) the count of close friends with whom the respondent interacts, and (b) the ability to remain connected to important foci for social interaction, such as voluntary associations.

Retention of connections to important interaction foci is measured using a scale that simply counts the distinct types of voluntary associations the respondent belongs to in each wave of the survey: these include private clubs, sport clubs, service organizations, and hobby clubs. These types of memberships are the kinds of interaction foci in which mass media and arts-related culture-mediated social interaction is most likely to play a key role in the formation and maintenance of social contacts (Long 2003), and thus on the likelihood that the individual will retain or drop the membership (McPherson, Popielarz, and Drobnic 1992; Popielarz and McPherson 1995).

Sociodemographic controls

The models shown below include the following sociodemographic controls: gender, age, education, city size, employment status, marital status, and presence of children in the household. The descriptive statistics of the variables are detailed in Table 4 of the Appendix.

Network driven taste loss

Analytic Strategy

The cultural taste loss model can be thought of as a discrete-time event history analysis spanning the pooled wave transitions (1985–1990 and 1990–1995) (Allison 1982). The dependent variable equals 1 if a cultural taste loss event is observed (the individual reported engaging in the activity "very often" in 1985, but "seldom" or "never" in the subsequent wave) and 0 otherwise.

To model this, I employ a pooled discrete-time logistic regression equation estimating the log odds of taste loss for each of the nine cultural activities. The predictors include a vector of network turnover indicators (e.g., changes in marital status, changes in work status, geographical mobility, changes in friends) as well as the standard matrix of sociodemographic controls. To account for the fact that observations for the same individual are not independent across time periods (unobserved heterogeneity within respondents), I estimate the models with cluster-robust standard errors (clustered by individual respondent). If the network hypothesis is correct (hypothesis 2), we should observe significant, positive coefficients for the network turnover indicators, implying that relational disruptions drive taste loss.

Results

Frequency of Taste Loss. Consistent with the cultural capital hypothesis, across all four cultural taste domains, taste loss is a relatively rare event. This is the case whether this is defined in a "strong" form (from "very often" in the first wave to "never" in the second) or in a weaker form (from "very often" to *either* "seldom" or "never"). Less than 3% of respondents go from having a strong taste in listening to music or reading the newspaper to losing that taste in the five-year period. A relatively larger number of respondents lose the taste for reading books or following sports, but the main empirical finding here is that the great majority of respondents retain their tastes (≈85–97%). This supports the cultural capital assumption that tastes are relatively stable over time, exhibiting stability rates that far exceed what is typically observed for personal networks (Suitor, Wellman, and Morgan 1997; Wellman *et al.* 1997).

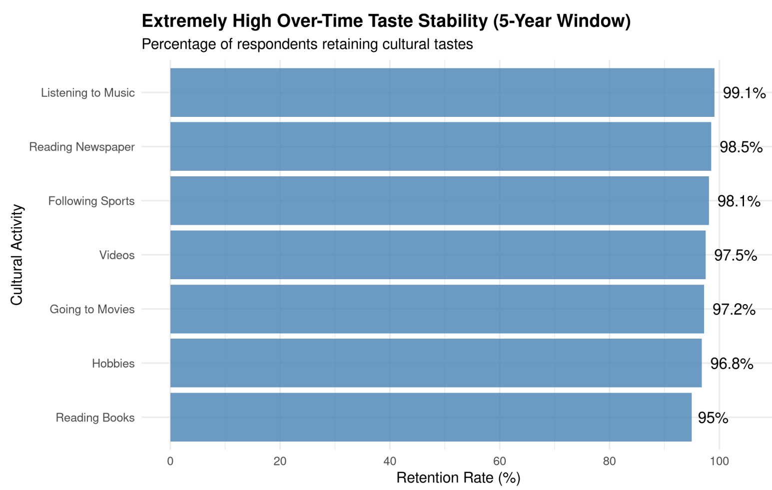

Figure 1: Extremely High Over-Time Taste Stability (5-Year Window). Most cultural practices show retention rates upwards of 95%.

Taste loss Models. The coefficient estimates of the discrete-time logistic regression models are shown in the Taste Change table below. All of the models have as the dependent variable a taste loss event defined according to the "weak" criterion above. Consistent with the expectations derived from the network-based taste transmission theory (Hypothesis 2), I find that—however rare—the cultural taste loss that can be observed is largely due to positional and social status changes associated with network turnover.

Thus, among the best predictors of cultural taste loss are changes in the frequency of *social interaction with friends* and changes in the *number of organizational memberships* (p<0.05 or p<0.10 for several cultural activities). Other important determinants of taste loss are status transitions that have been shown in the literature to be clearly associated with network turnover, such as changes in educational standing and changes in geographic location. The strongest effects in terms of magnitude are in accord with the view that tastes change when the personal network is transformed.

Changes in work status also have the expected positive effects on taste loss for select domains (like videos), although they are not uniformly significant across the board. The weakest effect of the entire set of network turnover indicators on taste loss pertains to changes in family status. Changes in marital status is not a useful uniform predictor of taste loss once other sources of network turnover are held constant, and changes in the number of children in the household have little discernible uniform effect. Possible reasons for the paucity of effects of changes in marital status include measurement error due to underestimating family volatility or the fact that there is little net effect of family status changes left after the primary relational outcomes of these changes (shifts in the frequency of interaction with friends) are held constant.

In all, it is safe to say that the network hypothesis is partially confirmed by these data. While the overall *rates* of cultural taste loss are so low as to conflict with standard network theory's assumptions of high taste malleability, the *sources* of taste loss when it does happen are largely those that we would expect: transformation of the personal network due to life-course changes associated with network turnover.

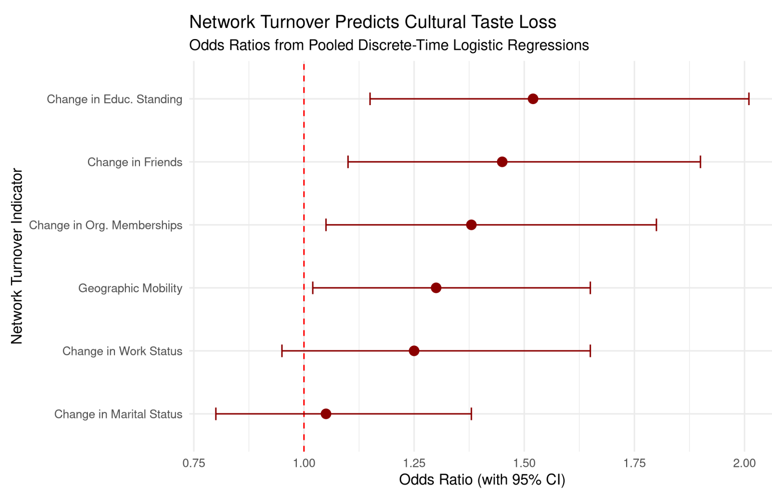

Figure 2: Network Turnover Predicts Cultural Taste Loss. Point estimates and 95% confidence intervals from pooled discrete-time logistic regressions.

Longitudinal Culture conversion model

Analytic Strategy

In this section, I estimate the potential causal effect of cultural capital (as measured by taste diversity) on the maintenance of network connectivity over time. Estimating this reciprocal effect longitudinally presents two major methodological challenges: unobserved individual heterogeneity (time-invariant individual-level factors correlated with both variables) and simultaneity bias.

To deal with these issues and properly model count-based network outcomes, I present a unified longitudinal modeling framework:

Mundlak (Within-Between) Poisson Models. I employ a Mundlak (within-between) specification using a Poisson regression framework. Standard random-effects models require the stringent assumption that unobserved individual-level heterogeneity is entirely uncorrelated with the regressors. The Mundlak approach relaxes this assumption by explicitly including the person-specific longitudinal means (the "between" effect) of the time-varying covariates alongside the group-mean-centered deviations (the "within" effect).

This allows us to cleanly disentangle the "within-person" effect (how temporary changes in an individual's cultural taste over time affect changes in their social connectivity) from the "between-person" effect (how stable, average differences in cultural tastes between individuals relate to average differences in social connectivity), thereby minimizing omitted variable bias.

Furthermore, because the primary outcome variables for social connectivity (the number of friends and the number of voluntary association memberships) are discrete, non-negative integer counts rather than continuous normal variables, these models are estimated using Poisson regressions. This ensures that the estimates correctly respect the variance structure of the count data.

Results

The culture conversion model (Lizardo 2006) implies that individuals who have command of a wide variety of tastes will be able to sustain larger and sparser personal networks over time, allowing them to reap the benefits of those social connections in the form of higher than average rates of social interaction and a higher ability to remain connected to important social foci where new contacts are made and old ones are sustained.

The results of the Mundlak (within-between) Poisson models of the effect of cultural capital (in the form of "omnivore" taste breadth) on network outcomes across time periods are shown below.

The results are highly consistent with the culture conversion model, particularly when examining the robust between-person differences (the 'mean' effects). I find that persons who display a persistently wide variety of tastes (a higher

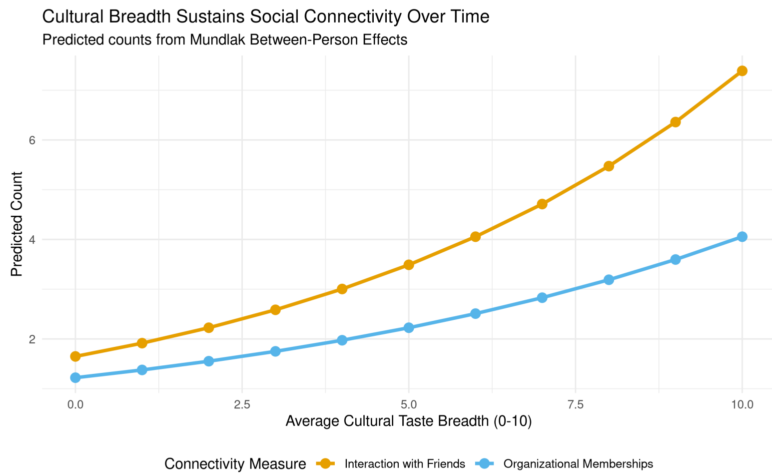

Figure 3: Cultural Breadth Sustains Social Connectivity Over Time. Predicted counts from Mundlak Between-Person Effects.

longitudinal mean of cultural breadth) sustain higher frequencies of social interaction with friends (p<0.05). While this cross-sectional "between" effect does not offer definitive evidence of strict causality, it cements in a robust longitudinal modeling framework the results previously reported by Lizardo (2006). Broad cultural tastes are strongly associated with sustaining larger and more active patterns of interpersonal engagement over time.

Furthermore, having a high average repertoire of tastes is not only useful in sustaining higher levels of informal social connectivity, but it also significantly raises the chances of remaining tied to important social foci of interaction, such as voluntary associations (p<0.05). Because recruitment (and the over-time stability of membership) into these foci is largely a matter of keeping alive the network ties that bind the individual to other members of the group (Popielarz and McPherson 1995), it is no surprise that whatever resource helps the individual to sustain social connections to other persons will also appear to sustain his or her connection to these larger social entities.

The Mundlak specification also allows us to evaluate the within-person effects—whether a temporary spike in an individual's cultural tastes over their own average translates to immediate gains in connectivity. The within-person effects for cultural taste breadth are smaller and only marginally significant for interaction with friends (p<0.1) and non-significant for organizational memberships. This suggests that it is the durable, trait-like possession of cultural capital (the between-person effect), rather than short-term fluctuations in cultural activity, that primarily drives sustained social connectivity and organizational integration over the life course.

Discussion and Conclusion

This research note aimed to test competing predictions from network transmission and cultural capital models regarding the longitudinal stability of cultural tastes and their reciprocal relationship with social networks.

The results reveal a clear pattern: cultural tastes exhibit remarkably high levels of stability over time (with roughly 98% retention over five-year periods), strongly contradicting the volatility corollary of traditional network transmission models. Tastes behave as durable forms of embodied cultural capital. However, the network-theoretic assumption that relational disruption drives taste loss receives strong support; when individuals do lose a taste, it is significantly predicted by network turnover events such as changes in friendship interaction, organizational memberships, and geographic mobility.

Furthermore, the Mundlak Poisson models provide robust evidence for the culture conversion model (Lizardo 2006). Between-person differences in cultural taste breadth significantly predict the maintenance of both informal social interactions (friends) and formal ties (organizational memberships) over time. The lack of significant within-person effects suggests that it is the stable, trait-like possession of cultural capital that maintains social connectivity, rather than short-term fluctuations in cultural activity.

Theoretical implications of these findings point toward a synthesis of the two models: tastes and networks operate in a feedback loop. Durable cultural tastes act as selective filters and stabilizing assets that help individuals maintain social ties (choice homophily), but structural shocks that disrupt these networks can subsequently erode cultural practices.

A limitation of this study is the reliance on proxy measures for network size (frequency of interaction and organizational memberships) rather than full ego-network data. Future research should utilize more granular, multi-wave personal network generators alongside detailed cultural consumption diaries to further untangle the micro-dynamics of how cultural capital sustains specific dyadic ties during life-course transitions.

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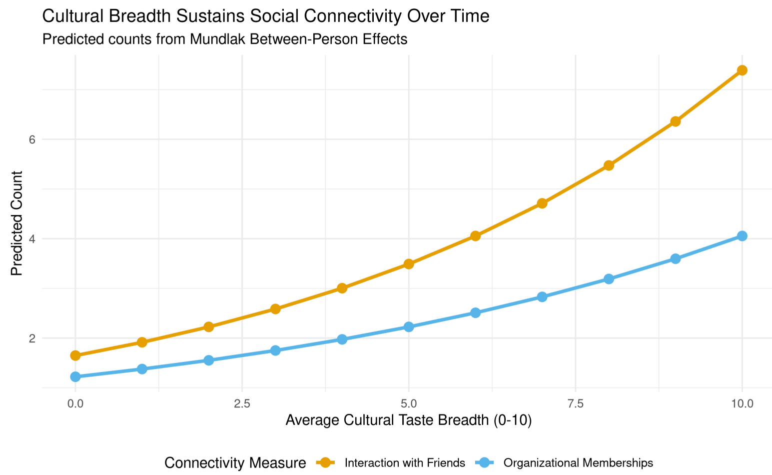

Figure 4: Cultural Breadth Sustains Social Connectivity Over Time. Predicted counts from Mundlak Between-Person Effects.

Table 4. Means, standard deviations and range of the variables used in the analysis. Project Canada Survey 1985-1995

Variable	N	Mean	Std Dev.	Min	Max
Δ Social Interaction	561	0.81	--	0	1
Δ Organizational Memberships	561	0.79	--	0	1
Δ Educational Status	561	0.33	--	0	1
Δ Geographic Location	561	0.53	--	0	1
Δ Work Status	561	0.24	--	0	1
Δ Marital Status	561	0.08	--	0	1
Δ N. of Children	561	0.08	--	0	1
Marital Status in 1985 (Married=1)	561	0.83	--	0	1
Marital Status in 1990 (Married=1)	561	0.81	--	0	1
Work Status in 1985 (Employed=1)	561	0.65	--	0	1
Work Status in 1990 (Employed=1)	561	0.58	--	0	1
Gender (Women=1)	561	0.67	--	0	1
City Size in 1985 (Large City=1)	561	0.53	--	0	1
City Size in 1990 (Large City=1)	561	0.52	--	0	1
Education in 1985	561	2.71	1.30	0	5

Variable	N	Mean	Std Dev.	Min	Max
Education in 1990	561	2.85	1.29	0	5
Age in 1985	561	51.53	13.30	19	87
Age in 1990	561	55.96	14.12	24	88
N. of Organizational Memberships in 1985	561	1.97	1.40	0	6
N. of Organizational Memberships in 1990	561	1.89	1.36	0	9
Freq. of Social Interaction in 1985	561	1.54	0.58	1	3
Freq. of Social Interaction in 1990	561	2.78	1.02	1	5
Culture Consumption Scale in 1980	339	6.76	1.19	3	8
Culture Consumption Scale in 1985	560	6.43	1.72	1	10
Culture Consumption Scale in in 1990	556	3.74	1.40	0	8

It is well known that measurement error attenuates the relationships between variables. This means that the relationship between two observed variables which are subject to measurement error will generally be weaker than their true relationship. For the analysis of change, this phenomenon implies that when the observed states are subject to measurement error, the strength of the relationships among the true states occupied at two subsequent points in time will be underestimated, or in other words, the amount of change will be overestimated. When the data are subject to measurement error, the observed transitions are, in fact, a mixture of true change and spurious change resulting from measurement error (Hagenaars, 1992; Van de Pol & De Leeuw, 1986). The latent Markov model makes it possible to separate true change and spurious change caused by measurement error (Vermunt et al, 1999: 184).

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Mixed Markov Latent Class Models

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